More about the *Pericope*

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The phrase, the *Pericope*, refers to John 7:53-8:11, twelve verses. They are omitted in about 15% of the extant Greek manuscripts, including all the early uncials except Codex D (Codex C has a large lacuna from 7:3–8:34, while Codex A has an even larger one, 6:50–8:52). But that means that 85% contain it, including the Latin tradition that dates from the 2nd century. That is older than any of the extant manuscripts. For over 200 years the academic world has generally challenged the authenticity of the passage. The old Nestle series of the Greek New Testament placed it in the footnotes. The more recent UBS/N-A series places it within double square brackets, [[ ]]. Here is their explanation: “Double square brackets are used to enclose passages which are regarded as later additions to the text”. Modern versions generally follow suit, in one way or another. The authenticity of the passage is at least questioned, if not rejected.

Assuming (just for the sake of the argument) that the passage is spurious, how could it ever have intruded here, and to such effect that it is attested by some 85% of the MSS, scattered all around the Mediterranean world? Let us try to read the larger passage without these verses—we must go directly from 7:52 to 8:12. Reviewing the context, the chief priests and Pharisees had sent officers to arrest Jesus, to no avail; a 'discussion' ensued; Nicodemus made a point, to which the Pharisees answered:

(7:52) "Are you also from Galilee? Search and look, for no prophet has arisen out of Galilee."

(8:12) Then Jesus spoke to them again, saying, "I am the light of the world . . . ."

What is the antecedent of the pronoun "them", and what is the meaning of the adverb "again"? By the normal rules of grammar, if 7:53-8:11 is missing, then the pronoun "them" must refer to the "Pharisees" and "again" means that there has already been at least one recent exchange. But 7:45 makes clear that Jesus **was not there** with the Pharisees, so without the *Pericope* 8:12 simply does not make sense. Thus, the UBS/N-A series and all so-called ‘critical’ editions introduce an aberration. Indeed, 8:12 presupposes 8:2. “At dawn He went again into the temple, and all the people were coming to Him; so sitting down He started to teach them.” Jesus was teaching the group of people around Him when He was rudely interrupted. After the interruption He resumed teaching the people.

Over 150 years ago Henry Alford argued that people offended by the episode would only have removed 8:3-11, not 7:53-8:11, and a few MSS actually do that. So Alford’s explanation for the omission of the *Pericope* would not explain the omission of 7:53-8:2. But Alford was mistaken. Consider: “So sitting down he started to teach them. Then Jesus spoke to them again, saying.” The ‘then’ and the ‘again’ simply do not make sense. So whoever wanted to get rid of the interruption had to remove verse 2 as well. But verse one has Jesus on the Mount of Olives, which wouldn’t work

either; so they also had to remove verse one. Whether 7:53 is there or not does not change the problem, but whoever engineered the omission decided to include it.

And yet, Bruce Metzger claimed that the passage "interrupts the sequence of 7.52 and 8.12 ff" (p. 220 in his 'Commentary'), which is obviously false. Did Metzger not know grammar? To look for the antecedents of 8:12 in 7:37-39 not only does despite to the syntax but also runs afoul of 8:13—"the Pharisees" respond to Jesus' claim in verse 12, but "the Pharisees" are somewhere else, see 7:45-52 (if the *Pericope* is absent).

Metzger also claimed that "the style and vocabulary of the pericope differ noticeably from the rest of the Fourth Gospel"—but would not the native speakers of Greek at that time have been in a better position than modern critics to notice something like that? So how could they allow such an "extraneous" passage to be forced into the text? I submit that the evident answer is that they did not; it was there all the time. I also protest their use of brackets here. Since the editors clearly regarded the passage to be spurious, they should have been consistent and deleted it, as did NEB and Williams.

In a fair number of MSS there is a squiggle, ~, in red ink in the margin against each line of text for the twelve verses. There have been those who used those squiggles as an argument against the passage. However, the very same squiggles, in the **same red ink**, are found in MSS from scattered monasteries. Evidently a single person had received the order to do that and carried his own pot of ink from place to place. It follows that those squiggles are fraudulent and should not be used as evidence.

Now I come to the witness of Family 35, that is part of the 85% mentioned above. As I recall, there is just one MS, against over 250 MSS that make up the family in the Gospels, that omits the passage. So Family 35 is all but unanimous in favor of the *Pericope*. If Family 35 is the line of transmission that God used to preserve the precise original wording of the NT, as I have argued elsewhere, then the passage, 7:53-8:11, is certainly genuine. But in any case, the internal evidence is conclusive. It was part of John's Gospel, right where it is, when he composed it. However, the question of the exact wording of the *Pericope* is a matter of some complexity that I will now consider.

In passing, in case it might be of interest to someone, I will mention Augustine. To those who asked: "Why was the story omitted?" leading church father and theologian, Augustine (about A.D. 430), answered: "Certain persons of little faith, or rather enemies of the true faith, fearing, I suppose, lest their wives should be given impunity in sinning, removed from their manuscripts the Lord's acts of forgiveness toward the adulteress, as if He who said 'sin no more' had granted permission to sin." (See Augustine, "Adulterous Marriages" [2.7] trans. by Charles T. Huegelmeyer, in *Saint Augustine: Treatises on Marriage and Other Subjects* [New York: Fathers of the

Church, 1955], p. 107.) [I took this material on Augustine from *Living Water: The Gospel of John—Logos 21 Version*, Absolutely Free Incorporated, p. 74.]

Hermann von Soden and his team collated over 900 MSS for those twelve verses. He reduced those 900 MSS to seven families, or lines of transmission, that he called $\mathbf{M}^{1,2,3,4,5,6,7}$ (the M being the first letter in 'adultery', in Greek). The last three families were by far the largest, any one of them being larger than the first four combined. Maurice A. Robinson has collated 1,505 continuous-text MSS for the twelve verses and confirms that those three families exist. The R-P Byzantine Priority Greek text (2005 edition) follows $\mathbf{M}^{5}$. The H-F Majority Greek text follows $\mathbf{M}^{6}$. The Family 35 Greek text follows $\mathbf{M}^{7}$. Comparing the three editions, does the objective evidence favor any one of them against the others?

I will now analyze that question. If two of them agree, they reflect the same source, and that source must be older than its derivatives. If we have a situation involving those three lines—call them **1**, **2**, **3**—that divide **1**&**2** X **3** and **1** X **2**&**3**, but never **1**&**3** X **2**, then **1**&**2** have the same source, and **2**&**3** have the same source. Now we face the question: do **1**&**2** and **2**&**3** have the same source, or do they have different sources? If they have the same source, then **2** is more faithful to that source than either **1** or **3**, being the common denominator. But how can we determine whether or not they have the same source? To answer that question I will use $\mathbf{M}^{5}$, $\mathbf{M}^{6}$ and $\mathbf{M}^{7}$ from the *Pericope*, or **5**, **6** and **7**.

My article, "Von Soden's treatment of his $\mathbf{K}^{r}$",[1] contains a comparison of the three at the 32 variant sets that are relevant to this exercise; that is, where one of them differs from the other two (based on Robinson's collations). When all three agree, they reflect the same source, of necessity. I made a rough count of the total of words within that stretch of text that are contained in all three families: there are 146. So for those 146 words, all three families have a common source, which is presumably the Original.

Now I will consider the places where **5** diverges from the other two: there are 18 words. For three of those words, **5** is internally divided. So what are we to conclude: for those 18 words, did **6**&**7** go astray and **5** stay with the common source? In such an event **6**&**7** would represent a node subsequent to the common source. But is it not far more likely that it was **5** that strayed, especially for the words where it is divided?

Now I will consider the places where **6** diverges from the other two, but the calculation is difficult because **6** is rather 'squishy', with considerable internal division. It is internally divided 17 times out of the total of 32 variant sets, and 12 of the 17 times one of the variants agrees with **7**, while 9 of those 12 times it also agrees with **5** (so at those 9 sets all three lines reflect the common source, albeit one of them does so only in part). There are 12 words where **6** diverges from the other two without division—did **5**&**7** go astray and **6** stay with the common source? Given its 'squishiness', it

[1] The article is available from my website, www.prunch.org, or any edition since 2021 of my books, *The Identity of the New Testament Text* and *God Has Preserved His Text*.

really seems more likely that it was **6** that strayed. If not, **5**&**7** would represent a node subsequent to the common source.

In most of the places where **5** or **6** differ from **7**, the change makes little or no difference to the narrative. The changes are possible, but not necessary. However, at the beginning of 8:1 either of the readings of **6** is inferior within the context, and the first of the two is clearly inferior. In 8:3, **5** apparently has a form of the verb 'to leave behind', instead of 'to seize', which does not make sense. If the form is supposed to represent 'to seize', it is misspelled and is 'peculiar'. The author, John, was a fisherman, whose Greek would not be classical or erudite. I take it that neither **6** nor **5** can have the original reading at those places, and **7** preserves the original. To be wrong even once does not help their credibility.

I need to inform the reader that in the above calculations I did not include one variant set where all three lines have something different (and the Lectionaries have a fourth major variant, which is curious, but this exercise does not include them). I also did not include another set that involves only a different spelling for the same word and where all lines have some division. Now then, **7** has a single, clear-cut, unambiguous profile/mosaic, as defined by 127 MSS—there is no internal variation among them (the 127 are precisely the same for all twelve verses). This contrasts dramatically with **6** and **5**. Further, **7** and **6** join against **5** fourteen times; **7** and **5** join against **6** nine times; but **6** and **5** join against **7** not one single time. So, does this mean that **7** is dependent on **5** and **6**, or does it mean that **5** and **6** are independent departures from **7**?

Just by the way, when **7** is joined by either **5** or **6** it is the 'majority' text. Nonetheless, Hodges chose to follow $\mathbf{M}^{\mathbf{6}}$, producing a 'minority' text. The first edition of R-P was mostly $\mathbf{M}^{\mathbf{7}}$, it being the 'majority'; however, for the second edition, 2005, they chose to follow $\mathbf{M}^{\mathbf{5}}$, producing a different 'minority' text.

If **6**&**7** and **5**&**7** both represent different nodes subsequent to the common source, how could **7** be part of both such nodes? How could **7** be a revision based on those nodes if it already existed? If there are no such nodes, then we have three independent lines of transmission. It is necessary to understand the significance of the absence of **5**&**6** X **7**. It means that the three lines are not equal. Either **7** is superior to the other two, or it is inferior to them. So which is it? The three lines have distinct profiles, or mosaics of readings. That is, they each have a list of variant readings that is different from all other such lists; each line has its own DNA, so to speak. That argues against the possibility that any two of them had a common source subsequent to the main source that is reflected in all three. The absence of a subsequent source means that **7** is more faithful to the main source than either of the other two and is therefore superior to them. It is the 'common denominator'. Also, the set where all three go separate ways proves that **7** is independent of the other two at that point; what objective basis is there for saying that it is not independent of them elsewhere as well? Remember that all three agree on 146 words, compared to **5**'s 18 private words, and **6**'s 12 private words—and **7**'s zero private words (except for the set where all three are different, and I did not count those words anywhere).

If anyone wishes to argue that **7** is a revision based on the other two, they should say who did it, when and where, and provide objective evidence for the claim. If a revision happened in stages, who directed those stages? And how could the same 'stage' happen in a variety of isolated monasteries? There are identical copies scattered all over the Mediterranean area. How could a revision achieve that distribution? At no time during the history of the Church was there a human controlling agency capable of producing that effect.

Does not the internal confusion that characterizes **6** undermine its claim to reliability? If so, it is the worst of the three. In stark contrast, besides the 127 manuscripts that are perfect **7**, another 55 are off by a single letter, that merely gives a different spelling to the same word (= 182 MSS); another 26 are off by a single change; another 27 are off by two changes (= 235 MSS), and so on. The level of internal consistency that characterizes **7** (Family 35) is extraordinary; no other line of transmission, anywhere in the NT, comes close to that level. If you believe that the Bible is God's Word, that declares God's intention to preserve it, what does that picture tell you?